



Critical Thinking and Study Skills: Destination College

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · ONE SEMESTER

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. Scholars may see some variation in activities and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Destination College applies critical thinking and study skills to the biggest research project of high school: choosing and applying to college. Scholars take honest personal stock, then work the decision from both directions — career-first and degree-first — before researching the schools that fit, the real cost of college and how families pay it (including the FAFSA), and the application process itself, admissions testing included. The semester culminates in a complete college essay, drafted paragraph by paragraph and polished for submission. Scholars finish with a plan that is genuinely theirs, built on evidence rather than guesswork.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Introduction and Personal Stock (Module 1)

Understanding higher education and taking an honest inventory of strengths, interests, and goals.

3 Colleges (Module 3)

Finding the best schools for a degree or career, the types of colleges, and the other factors that matter.

5 Applying to College (Module 5)

General preparation, the application itself, admissions testing, and bringing it all home.

2 Majors and Careers (Module 2)

Finding the right degree two ways — career-first and degree-first — anchored by self-assessment.

4 Money (Module 4)

The real cost of college, finding funding, and FAFSA, taxes, and net price — the numbers families actually need.

6 The College Essay (Module 6)

A complete essay built step by step — topic, body paragraphs, introduction, conclusion — and submitted polished.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- One to two lessons per week across the semester, each building toward the scholar's own college plan.
- Research tasks with real tools: school search, cost calculators, and funding sources.
- The college essay drafted in stages, with feedback along the way.
- Required office-hours check-ins connect each scholar with the facilitator.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday, for one semester

- Lessons and research work fill most of the scheduled time.
- Essay-drafting weeks may run longer.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- A notebook for research notes and college lists.
- Microsoft 365 and OneDrive (provided to every scholar) for the college essay.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, when offered live; for 2026–27 it is listed as an On-Demand course.